Roblox hit game concept design

Build a pet-riding ranch that ends each night

Harry should build **an original pet-collecting "hatch-and-ride" ranch game with a short day/night cycle**. The working title used here is *Lantern Isles: Hatch & Ride*. Each creature you hatch is both a reward and a tool, because its mutation gives your mount a new way to move. A five-minute co-op **"Dusk Run"** gives every session a shared high point and a natural ending. A ranch that others can visit, trading and a weekly hosted "Lantern Festival" supply the long-term social life. This combines the strongest current formula with the features that keep classics alive. The 2026 breakouts (Steal An Egg, Ride A Pet) turn a collected pet into the progression stat. The classics that last years (Adopt Me!, MM2, Brookhaven) rely on social systems that don't run out of content and on a predictable update rhythm. The timing matters because Roblox changed the rules in 2026. Since June, Recommended For You ranks games on **28-day retention, play-through rate and first-play bounce**. In August, after Steal An Egg went viral, Roblox said endless-feed games **"without natural stopping points"** would be blocked for younger accounts. Odds disclosure, PolicyService gating and the Kids/Select gate now decide who can see a game and what it may sell. Harry's strengths in Luau, UI, shops and monetization fit the hardest part of a 2026 game: a compliant, honest store that still converts. The money is real but heavily skewed. Estimates put a well-monetized game's owner net at **about $0.015–0.025 per daily user per day**. On that basis a game holding about 1,000 average CCU earns **roughly $4–7K a month**, while a typical small game earns **a few hundred dollars a year**. Harry should treat this as a portfolio-building bet, keep freelancing alongside it, and judge it on D1 and D7 within eight weeks of a soft launch. A caveat applies to everything below. Almost every source was read **through search-engine snippets**, because the research sandbox could not fetch create.roblox.com, the DevForum, RoWatcher and most press sites. The game concept, prices, timeline and revenue scenarios are **design proposals and inferences**, not findings.

How to read this report. The first three sections summarize evidence and cite sources inline. Sections four to six are design proposals built on that evidence, and statements there are marked as evidence, proposal or estimate where the difference matters. Tracker figures for CCU and revenue (RoWatcher, Profitable.app, Zing, Rolimons) are third-party models that often disagree with each other by 3–5×.

The 2025–26 hits share one loop, and the classics add one durable layer

The viral hits of 2025 and 2026 have a strikingly similar structure. Steal An Egg, #1 on Roblox in September and October 2026, has players run through biomes to grab eggs, hatch them at their base into pets that earn money, and spend the money on speed and access to better areas. **Speed is the critical stat**, and it can be trained on a treadmill or bought with Robux (PocketGamer).

Players can steal eggs from NPC biomes or from other players' bases. Ride A Pet (launched April 2026) refined the idea. Players find eggs, hatch them on a ranch plot, then **ride the pets for speed** to reach rarer eggs, and mutations make pets faster (Beebom). Grow a Garden runs a plant, wait, harvest, sell and expand loop with randomized mutations, a rotating seed shop and prestige resets, which RoLearn calls "simple, satisfying, and infinitely scalable" (RoLearn). Fisch built value on **70+ mutation multipliers** (HDG). Fish It! then reached a **2.7M CCU** peak by simplifying Fisch into a forgiving cast-reel-sell loop (Max Power Gaming, Rolimons). The shared anatomy has five parts: a one-verb action that pays off in under a minute, rarity multiplied by mutation, a visible base that doubles as a trophy shelf, Robux that removes a constraint, and a "show your friends" moment.

The outliers show other ways to win. Dress to Impress gives players about five minutes to build an outfit for a theme, then has them vote on each other's looks. Its viral unit was a **creative output** that clipped well on TikTok (the "Pose 28" meme), not a rare drop (Wikipedia). 99 Nights in the Forest built a co-op day/night survival loop. By day players gather and craft. At night they must keep the campfire fed while a deer that cannot be killed hunts outside its light. Friends fall into scout, cook and crafter roles without locked classes (PCGamer, Bloxodes). It peaked near **14.15M CCU** (Players.com.ua). Dead Rails won, according to GameAnalytics, with a "most advanced yet acceptable" concept plus repeated influencer and algorithm exposure (GameAnalytics).

What separates a classic from a spike is **a layer that works without new content**. In MM2, the tradeable knife inventory keeps players logging in after they stop playing rounds, and seasonal boxes revalue old inventories (StudioKrew). Adopt Me! has shipped **every week since it adopted a weekly schedule**, with an in-game countdown to the next update (Uplift FAQ). Brookhaven's open roleplay is playable **without spending** (Noping). Uplift's stated design rule is the best one-line brief for Harry: keep "every mechanic understandable, while giving the right level of depth to systems like building and trading that older audiences enjoy" (Roblox Newsroom).

Spikes, by contrast, collapse. Grow a Garden fell from a 22M peak to 7.6M **within an hour** (Outlook Respawn). Fisch "collapsed under heavy monetization and ownership changes" (Max Power Gaming). RoWatcher estimates that **about 80% of 2024's top-50 games were outside the top 200 by early 2026** (RoWatcher), a single-outlet figure with unverified methods. Live spectacle is the most repeatable growth lever. Steal a Brainrot's developer-hosted "Admin Abuse" events flood the map with rare units for 30–45 minutes (Lootester). The staged Grow a Garden versus Steal a Brainrot "admin war" on August 23, 2025 pushed Roblox to a **47.4M platform CCU record** (Tubefilter). Even the biggest hit found weekly content hard to sustain. Grow a Garden's lead apologized for "repetitive" updates and switched to **depth over quantity** (NME), and Steal a Brainrot now updates roughly every six weeks, according to an unofficial tracker (allthings.how).

Player sentiment points to the same opening. Players praise rare pulls, heists, chaotic shared events, cozy growth and co-op roles. Critics attack randomized rewards, Robux time-skips and rotating FOMO shops (Andy Hall, Free Systems), along with Robux-bought speed and defense gear that decides PvP stealing (Wikipedia). Direct Reddit sentiment could not be retrieved. The inference is clear, though. **A game that keeps the rarity and heist thrill but sells expression and convenience instead of PvP power fits both players and policy.**

Roblox now rewards 28-day retention and penalizes endless feeds

The discovery rules changed under every new game in 2026. Roblox's June 15 post moved Recommended For You from a 7-day to a **28-day view that directly measures long-term retention**, adding play-through rate and first-play bounce as signals alongside spend (Roblox Newsroom). The docs call **play-through rate** (how often players who see the game in the sort go on to play it) the most important signal. They treat **first-play bounce**, bucketed at under 60 seconds and 61–180 seconds, as negative, and they track play days per user across D1, D2–D7 and D8–D28 (Creator Hub: Discovery). Signals are **per-user averages, not totals** (Discovery FAQ). That means a small, well-targeted audience can outrank a big careless one. Roblox told shareholders the change "intentionally provides more impressions for highly retentive games at the expense of near term monetization" (Nasdaq). Thumbnail personalization favors the image with the best *qualified* play-through, for an average **+8.5% lift** (Thumbnails docs), so clickbait now loses twice. The bar is low but real: the median D1 retention is about **10.3%** (GameAnalytics 2026). Roblox also publishes **Standout Games**, a curated sort for novel mechanics, distinctive visual styles or underrepresented genres, reached by nomination (Creator Hub). Its ads docs warn that non-unique games may get no ad delivery and lower search rank (creator-docs).

Policy now shapes the design itself. Steal An Egg was pulled offline in August 2026 after passing 500K CCU (InGameNews). Roblox then said games that "reward users to consume a continuous feed of content without natural stopping points" would not be allowed for younger accounts unless they changed (MassivelyOP). The audience is split by account type. **Roblox Kids (5–8)** sees only Minimal or Mild games that passed selection, with chat off by default. **Roblox Select (9–15)** sees up to Moderate. Unverified accounts are limited to Minimal and Mild (Roblox Newsroom). Among age-checked users in March 2026, **36% were under 13** and 38% were 13–17 (Q1 2026 letter). To reach under-16s, a creator needs:

- age verification and 2-Step Verification;
- a maturity rating of Moderate or lower;
- a refundable 1,000 R$ fee, or a Plus or Premium subscription at least two months old;
- **250 unique plays from highly engaged, age-checked players within 60 days**, scored on tenure, playtime and spend anywhere on Roblox (creator-docs, Kids and Select, DevForum).

Experience notifications reach **only users 13+**, must tie to real in-game activity, and cannot be required to progress (Creator Hub). Roughly **80% of users reach Roblox on phones or tablets**, per Newzoo (GameDev Reports).

Roblox remains a social platform first, and that is the design lever. In two studied games, **34–45% of returning players logged in without doing a core action**, just to hang out (Game Developer). One dataset puts Roblox players **75% above genre average on social competition and 56% above on social cooperation** (PocketGamer.biz). Roblox's Friend Referral system lets developers read the referrer from join data and reward both players (Creator Hub). The inference for design is that **natural stopping points are now a requirement, not a nicety**. A day/night cycle, a round end or a "your eggs incubate overnight" beat meets the August rule and builds the multi-day return habit the 28-day signal measures.

The money is concentrated, and compliance now shapes the shop

Top games sell on a familiar price ladder. Blox Fruits gamepasses, as listed by community value sites, run from **about 350 R$** (Fast Boats) through 450 R$ (2x Money, 2x Mastery) and 1,200 R$ (Dark Blade) to **2,700 R$** (Fruit Notifier) (bloxfruitsvalues.com). Grow a Garden's Season 1 Pass cost **749 R$** for the premium track, with **49 R$ per level skip** or 1,699 R$ for the whole ladder (Sportskeeda). Its limited "Forever Pack", priced in escalating steps from 37 to 435 R$, drew "scam" complaints (Gamewave.fr). RIVALS earns "almost entirely through weapon skins and battle passes", which RoWatcher estimates at **$8–15M+ a month** (RoWatcher). That proves a cosmetics-first model can reach the top. Roblox's own guidance warns that appointment mechanics and removable timers are unpopular, and says "tourists" prefer purchases with immediate value (Roblox monetization docs).

Platform-level conversion is thin. Newzoo, via a secondary summary, puts **about 1.25% of daily users purchasing on a given day** and daily bookings at **about $0.14 per DAU** (GameDev Reports). GameAnalytics found over half of payers spend under $1 a year, though that is 2023 data (GameAnalytics 2023). After Roblox's 30% marketplace fee and DevEx conversion, RoWatcher estimates a well-monetized game nets its owner **about $0.015–0.025 per DAU per day** (RoWatcher). At the low end, one developer reported that a game averaging **60–78 CCU earns about 25K R$ a year**, roughly $95 at DevEx (DevForum). Among more than 42,000 DevEx participants the **median earned about $1,500** in the year to June 2026, while the top 1,000 averaged $1.4M (TweakTown). Third-party revenue estimates for hits range from about $1.4M a month for Steal a Brainrot (RoWatcher) to **$8–14M a month for Blox Fruits** (RoWatcher). Grow a Garden reportedly made **$12M in May 2025 alone** (Calcalist).

Harry's income streams in 2026 are broader than gamepasses alone:

Stream	How it pays	Key rule or figure	Source
Gamepasses and developer products	~70% of the Robux price after the 30% fee	Core of revenue	Roblox docs
Paid private servers	Robux, plus a Plus bonus of up to 100 R$ per Plus subscriber who spends 60+ min there	Qualifies for the 18+ DevEx rate	Roblox Plus docs
Roblox Plus sign-ups	Up to 750 R$ per new subscriber prompted in game via `PromptRobloxSubscriptionPurchase`	60-day hold	Roblox Plus docs
Creator Rewards	5 R$ per Active Spender daily visit; 35% of new or returning users' first $100	Rewards daily return	DevForum
Experience subscriptions	Fiat recurring payments	Count toward the 18+ rate	80.lv
Rewarded video ads	EPM × impressions, **13+ users only**	~$3–15 per 1K DAU per month (third-party)	rolearn.dev
Managed Pricing	Regional prices set at 30–100% of the default	Payer share rose 52% in the Philippines in tests	Roblox Newsroom

Stream	How it pays	Key rule or figure	Source
Commerce / AMP merch, brand deals	Physical goods; brand integrations pay a CPM fee to Roblox from 2027 ($1.50 per 1K US visits)	Only matters at scale	PocketGamer.biz

DevEx pays **$0.0038 per earned Robux**, or **$0.0054 on qualifying spend by age-verified US adults**, with a **30,000 R$ minimum** and 18+ ID verification (18+ DevEx docs). Payouts run through Tipalti, which charges a 1.9–3% FX fee (DevEx Portal docs). **No source confirmed which Tipalti payout methods reach Nigeria.** Harry should verify this before relying on game income.

The compliance rules are concrete. **Paid random items** include anything bought with Robux, or with currency that was bought with Robux. They must show numeric odds before purchase, give every outcome some value, and be blocked through PolicyService `ArePaidRandomItemsRestricted` where restricted (Community Standards, Roblox monetization docs). Per-outcome odds must sum to 100%, and the rule covers **luck boosts** (paid random items docs). They are restricted for UK under-18s, and in Brazil for under-18s and for adults who have not verified their age (DevForum, Bloxy News). The University of Sydney's March 2026 study of the 15 top-earning games found **deceptive monetization in 14 of them**. The tactics included always-on "discounts", prices hidden behind nested currencies, near-miss visuals and false-urgency countdowns (USyd, ACS Information Age). Those tactics are a ready-made list of things Harry's shop should never do.

Lantern Isles: hatch, ride and light the coast together *(design proposal)*

Everything in this section is a **design proposal** that applies the evidence above. Name candidates are *Lantern Isles: Hatch & Ride*, *Critter Coast* and *Ride the Tide*. Harry should search Roblox and trademark databases for each before committing.

Pitch, audience and identity

The pitch: "Hatch wild creatures, ride them across glowing islands, and light the lighthouses with your server before the tide comes in." It is **pet collecting plus a traversal verb**, the strongest current pattern, with three distinctive twists:

- **Mutations change how a creature moves, not just its value.** A Tidal mutation swims, Gale glides, Crystal climbs walls and Ember dashes. Every rare pull opens new map routes, so the creature is both reward and tool, as in Ride A Pet.
- **A five-minute co-op Dusk Run** borrows the 99 Nights day/night structure but without horror.
- **Ranches are open for visits.** Other players can walk through your ranch, and a weekly "Ranch of the Week" vote borrows Dress to Impress's creative showcase.

The steal thrill survives in a gentle form. "Sneaky Critters", NPC raccoon-like pests, try to snatch eggs from ranch pens, and the server can defend together. An optional round-based arena called **"Egg Tag"** lets players grab a golden egg from each other inside a three-minute match that ends. There is no PvP theft from bases, so nobody can lose their collection to another player, and no Robux item decides a fight.

Target audience and rating:

- **Core audience: Select (9–15).** This group wants collection status, trading and light competition.
- **Fully playable for Kids (5–8).** The UI is icon-driven, nothing depends on chat, and losing never costs you anything.
- **Depth for 13+.** Older players get ranch decoration, trading and Mutation Codex completion.
- **Rating: Minimal or Mild.** This is a business choice. It keeps the whole funnel open, including unverified accounts, and avoids the Moderate cutoff.

Identity hook: a **distinctive art direction** helps with the Standout Games sort and is easier to defend against copycats than mechanics. The proposal is a bright, stylized coast at golden hour. Creature markings could draw on West African textile patterns such as adire indigo and kente-style geometry. That would give Harry an underrepresented look he can credibly own. Weather names can also be local, such as a "Harmattan Haze" event. This is an optional creative bet, not a requirement. The baseline is one cohesive palette, readable silhouettes on low-end phones, and "juice" on every action: tweened pops, particles, sounds and server-wide banners for rare hatches.

The 30-second loop, session goals and stopping points

The core loop takes about 30 seconds. Players **ride** (about 8 seconds), **spot** a glowing wild egg or creature (about 5 seconds), and **catch** it with a one-thumb timing lasso. The lasso is forgiving, in the style of Fish It!, with no near-miss theatrics (about 5 seconds). They **send** the catch to the nursery from a Lantern Post (about 5 seconds) and get a **payout**: shells pop out and the next upgrade lights up (about 7 seconds).

The first-time experience is built for the bounce buckets in the discovery docs:

Time	What happens
Spawn	The player is already riding a starter creature. No cutscene.
~20 s	First egg caught.
~60 s	First hatch, with a big reveal.
~3 min	First mutation reveal, which opens a route that was locked.
~5 min	First Dusk Run starts on the server, so new players join a shared moment straight away.

A day lasts **about 15 minutes**. Each session gives players a few clear goals:

- three daily Keeper Tasks;
- tonight's nursery eggs;
- one pen upgrade;
- the Dusk Run;
- an optional Ranch of the Week entry.

Stopping points are built in. Each night ends with a recap card: creatures found, shells earned, the eggs incubating overnight (2–8 hours), and the Festival countdown. Daily tasks are capped. The nursery queue has a fixed size. There is no infinite feed or auto-roll. These are deliberate answers

to the August 2026 policy, and each one creates a reason to come back tomorrow, which feeds the play-days signal. Target session length is 15–25 minutes, between the 8–12 minutes typical of meme games and the 30–60 minutes of social RPGs that RoWatcher reports (RoWatcher).

Long-term progression and social systems

Progression has five layers:

1. **Island chain.** Two islands at MVP, then one more every 3–6 weeks. Each is gated by a movement mutation rather than by Robux.
2. **Creature Codex.** About 30 species × 6 mutations at launch. This is the collection chase, and the odds are shown for every outcome even when no Robux is involved.
3. **Moving Day (prestige).** Relocate the ranch to a grander island tier for a permanent shells multiplier and new decor. Early cycles are tuned to about 30–60 minutes of focused play, per the rebirth guidance (creation.dev), and later cycles get longer.
4. **Ranch decoration and Keeper Rank.** This is the long-term status layer.
5. **Six-week seasons.**

The social systems include:

- **ranch visits and likes**, with a weekly showcase;
- **tandem riding**: big creatures carry a friend, which makes inviting someone instantly useful;
- **trading** of earned creatures, with two-step confirmation and a visible trade history;
- **friend referral rewards**: a matching "Buddy Lantern" creature skin for both the inviter and the new player;
- **invite prompts** fired at moments of excitement, such as a rare hatch or the start of a Dusk Run;
- **server-wide Dusk Run rewards**, so a stranger joining helps everyone.

Items bought with Robux are cosmetics and stay **untradeable**. This limits real-money trading and scams. Event creatures earned through play can be traded, which gives the game an MM2- and Adopt Me-style economy without selling power.

LiveOps calendar a solo developer can sustain

The cadence copies what the evidence says works: a fixed weekly event, a larger update every few weeks, and content added as data rather than code.

Rhythm	What ships	Evidence it borrows from
Every Wednesday	Weather rotation (new mutation odds, all disclosed)	Adopt Me weather rotation (TheClick)
Every Saturday, fixed time	30-minute **Lantern Festival**: Harry joins as "the Keeper", triggers rare weather and a festival-only creature, and everyone online gets it	Admin Abuse events (Lootester), without fake scarcity
Every 3–6 weeks	New island or biome, 5–8 species, one new movement ability	Grow a Garden's shift to "depth over quantity", Steal a Brainrot's ~6-week rhythm

Rhythm	What ships	Evidence it borrows from
Every 6 weeks	New Tide Pass season with cosmetic track	Grow a Garden Season Pass
Holidays	Halloween "Spooky Tide", year-end "Harmattan Haze", April Fools remix	Adopt Me weekly Halloween drops; Doors April Fools remixes (Wikipedia)
At 5K+ CCU	Crossover with another mid-size developer (shared festival creature)	The 2025 admin war; the Steal An Egg × Sammy crossover

Every new creature should be **one config row plus one model**, so weekly drops need no code changes. Before any large change, Roblox's Experiments tool and its new early-warning alerts can catch regressions (Roblox Newsroom).

A deterministic-first shop priced on the proven ladder *(design proposal)*

The catalog below reuses the hits' price ladder: impulse items at 25–129 R$, core passes at 350–499 R$, a season pass around 700 R$ and prestige items at 1,200 R$ or more. It **sells convenience, expression and capacity, never PvP power or paid randomness at launch**. The "net to Harry" column assumes 70% of the price at the standard $0.0038 DevEx rate, which is about 0.27 cents per Robux of list price. Prices are proposals. Managed Pricing should be switched on so it can test them and set regional discounts (30–100% of default), which matters for players in Nigeria, the Philippines and Brazil.

Item	Type	Price (R$)	Net to Harry (≈ USD)	Design note
Keeper Starter Pack (saddle skin, 2 extra pens, shells)	One-time dev product	99	$0.26	Tourist-friendly immediate value; shown once, no countdown
Extra Pens +4	Gamepass	349	$0.93	Capacity, not power
Saddlebag (carry 2 eggs per trip)	Gamepass	299	$0.79	Convenience
Auto-Collect Shells	Gamepass	399	$1.06	Classic 2x-style pass without breaking balance
VIP Lagoon (cosmetic area, name tag, extra daily task)	Gamepass	499	$1.33	Status
Lantern Trail cosmetics	Gamepass	199	$0.53	Visible to others
Mutation Dye (choose a cosmetic colorway for one creature)	Dev product	149	$0.40	Deterministic, so it is not a paid random item
Instant Hatch	Dev product	49	$0.13	Timers stay short (2–8 h) so this stays optional

Item	Type	Price (R$)	Net to Harry (≈ USD)	Design note
Tide Pass premium (6 weeks)	Dev product/pass	699	$1.86	Cosmetic track only; no paid tier skips at launch
Royal Stable decor set	Gamepass	1,299	$3.45	Prestige item
Private island server	Private server	~100/month	$0.27 + Plus bonus	Qualifies for the 18+ rate and the Plus private-server bonus
Roblox Plus prompt	Platform	—	Up to 750 R$ per new subscriber	One tasteful prompt at the end-of-night recap
Rewarded video "bonus lantern"	Ad	—	~$3–15 per 1K DAU per month	Shown to 13+ only, opt-in, never offered under 13

The compliance rules are built into the code from day one. **No paid randomness ships in the MVP.** If paid luck items are added in a later phase, such as a "Moon Lantern" that raises mutation chances, they are paid random items. Each one needs a per-outcome odds table summing to 100% shown before purchase, every outcome must have value, and a PolicyService check must swap in a deterministic alternative where restricted. Earned-currency hatches also show odds, as goodwill. All prices are shown in Robux, never only in shells. There are no permanent "sale" banners and no fake timers, and the only countdowns are real festival start times. A "My purchases" panel shows a spend recap. The **USyd list of 14 deceptive practices serves as a pre-launch checklist**.

Harry should apply for the Kids/Select gate once the game holds steady:

- **Before applying:** ID verification, 2FA and either the refundable 1,000 R$ fee or two months of Plus.
- **The gate itself:** 250 highly engaged plays within 60 days.
- **Fallback:** if organic plays fall short, run a small Ads Manager **Engagement** campaign, which the docs say costs more per play (creator-docs).

Ship an MVP in about ten weeks, then let D1 decide *(proposal and estimates)*

Scope and milestones for a solo developer using Studio AI

The evidence on speed points both ways. Grow a Garden's first version took "three or four days" (ODT/RNZ), and Studio Assistant can now write code, run playtests, simulate input and take screenshots through its MCP server (DevForum). But players and clients push back on visibly AI-made assets (GosuGamers). The proposed plan therefore uses AI for boilerplate, test automation and greybox work, and spends Harry's own time on feel, UI and the economy.

The MVP has:

- 2 islands;
- about 12 species with 4 mutations, three of which unlock movement;

- the ranch with pens and visits;
- the nursery with offline hatch;
- the Dusk Run;
- daily tasks;
- DataStore saving with session locking;
- the shop above, minus the Tide Pass;
- analytics events at each step of the first-time experience;
- 8–10 player servers, small so they look full (RoWatcher, practitioner opinion).

Hero creature models are worth commissioning. Freelance rates run about $15–60 an hour, and small builds cost 1K–10K R$ (Game-Ace). Free models carry backdoor risk.

Weeks (from Oct 26, 2026)	Milestone	Exit test
1	Paper design, economy spreadsheet, 3 mock thumbnails, name check	Thumbnails say "ride + hatch" without text
2–4	Vertical slice: ride, lasso, nursery, ranch, save	First hatch within 60 s in a cold test
5–6	Dusk Run, day/night recap, mutations-as-movement, shop and odds UI, PolicyService checks	Night cycle ends cleanly; purchase flows tested
7	Polish pass (juice, sound, mobile UI), Playtest Agent regression runs, low-end phone test on Nigerian mobile data	60 fps target on a mid-range Android
8	Closed playtest (friends, Discord, ~30–100 players), no public demo because of copycat risk	Qualitative "one more night?" signal
9–10	Soft launch (late Dec 2026 to early Jan 2027), Plays-goal ads at small budget, 2–4 thumbnails in personalization	D1, bounce, play-through readings
11–14	Iterate on the hook; Kids/Select application; first Saturday Festivals; Season 1 Tide Pass	Gates below

The **go/no-go gates**, all proposals, are as follows. Keep iterating on the hook, without adding content or ads, while D1 sits below about 10% (the median) or under-60-second bounce is high after a few thousand plays. Scale ads and seed creators only once **D1 is about 15–25%, D7 is about 5–8%, D28 play-days per user are rising, and payer conversion is at or above the platform's ~1.25%**. Creator Analytics benchmarks against similar games (50th–90th percentile, available at 100+ DAU) should replace these placeholder targets as soon as they appear (Creator Hub Analytics).

Launch plan and KPIs

The paid channel inside Roblox is Ads Manager. It uses auto-bid cost per play with Plays, Earnings and Engagement goals. Campaigns can rotate up to ten 16:9 thumbnails, and the first 24 hours are a learning phase (creator-docs). An unverified third-party estimate puts cost at **4–12 R$ per visit** (RoWatcher). At that rate, 5,000 test plays would cost about 20K–60K R$. The proposed launch budget is **$150–400 in ad credit across two or three 3–5-day tests**, plus **$50–300 for micro-**

influencer shoutouts, which start around $1.50–20 each (CollabPals). Harry should also post **3–5 Shorts or TikToks a week** of rare hatches and festival chaos (Eklipse), run a Roblox group and Discord for update pings, and nominate the game for Standout Games with a gameplay video once the art is final. The evidence on how hits are made argues for patience. Grow a Garden went from about **500 to about 100K CCU in roughly two weeks after weekly live updates began** (GamesBeat), and a hit is amplified by creators, not created by them (RoLearn).

KPI	Where to read it	Proposed early target
RFY play-through rate	Creator Analytics > Acquisition	Top half of benchmark
First-play bounce (<60 s, 61–180 s)	Discovery metrics	Falling week over week
D1 / D7 retention	Retention	≥15–25% / ≥5–8%
D8–D28 play days per user	Discovery/retention	Rising each season
Session length	Engagement	15–25 min
Payer conversion	Monetization	≥1.25% of DAU
ARPDAU (owner net)	Monetization (derived)	$0.015–0.025
Kids/Select highly-engaged plays	Publishing status	250 within 60 days

Revenue scenarios *(clearly labeled estimates)*

These scenarios multiply average CCU by 9 to approximate DAU, an assumption Zing marks as low confidence (Zing). They then apply RoWatcher's single-author owner-net estimate of $0.015–0.025 per DAU per day. They are illustrations, not forecasts. Most new games never reach the first row.

Scenario	Avg CCU	≈ DAU	Owner net per month (USD)	Reality check
Weak monetization	60–78	~600	~$8 (DevForum actual: ~25K R$/yr)	What happens when the shop doesn't convert
Small but healthy	100	~900	~$400–675	Near the DevEx median for a year's work
Niche success	1,000	~9,000	~$4,000–6,750	A life-changing income in Nigeria; Creator Rewards and Plus add a little more
Breakout	10,000	~90,000	~$40,000–67,500	Usually triggers copycats and publisher offers
Hit	100,000+	~900,000	~$400,000+	Top-1,000 creator territory

Rewarded video would add only about $27–135 a month at 9,000 DAU. Paid luck items, added later and fully compliant, could lift ARPDAU but carry regional restrictions and reputational risk. If the game breaks out, the evidence shows a common next step. Grow a Garden's creator kept about 50% after Splitting Point took a stake, and DoBig and Gamefam acquire or invest in promising games (GamesBeat, IBTimes). That trades equity for LiveOps capacity and ad budget. It is worth considering only with a written contract.

Risks and how the design answers them

Copycats are near-certain. Steal a Brainrot's developers have filed **at least four lawsuits** against imitators (Bloomberg), and indie developers are switching to closed playtests (GamingHQ). Harry's defenses are:

- distinctive characters and art, which are easier to protect than mechanics;
- weekly speed that clones can't match;
- a group and Discord community;
- copyright registration if traction appears.

Trends decay. Pet-and-egg games could fade the way brainrot did. The durable layers (trading, ranch showcases, co-op nights, seasons) are meant to outlast the trend, and they are the part to protect if the pet theme cools.

Policy can move again. Stopping points, no launch-time paid RNG, ads and notifications limited to 13+, and a Minimal/Mild rating keep the game on the safe side of every 2026 rule found. Harry still needs to re-read the official pages, which this research saw only as snippets.

Practical risks:

- **Latency:** West African latency affects testing (Change.org petition).
- **Payouts:** DevEx availability for Nigeria via Tipalti is unconfirmed.
- **Account security:** malware-driven game takeovers are a documented threat to developers (Malwarebytes). The game should live in a 2FA-protected group, and Harry should never run files from "employers".
- **Burnout:** a solo weekly cadence is the main execution risk. The data-driven content pipeline and the depth-over-quantity rhythm exist to manage it.

Two shorter alternatives

Alternative A, *Critter Couture Showdown*. A Dress to Impress-style creative round for Harry's UI strength. Players get four minutes to assemble a creature from parts (body, pattern, accessories) to a theme, show it on a runway or obstacle parade, and vote. Monetization is cosmetic parts, a VIP wardrobe and a seasonal pass. It has natural round ends, very clippable outputs, Minimal rating and no randomness. The risk is that it depends on server population and has weaker idle return.

Alternative B, *Last Lantern Market*. A 99 Nights-style co-op night-defense round of about 15 minutes. Friends run a market stall by day and defend it from mischievous spirits at night, with emergent roles and cosmetic and class meta-progression. Its strengths are strong co-op retention and clean stopping points. Its risks are more content per hour, a larger scope, and a likely Mild-to-Moderate rating that could narrow the Kids audience.

Conclusion

In 2026 the winning question shifted from "what spikes?" to "what keeps players coming back for 28 days, inside the rules?" Under that test, the strongest original bet blends the creature-as-tool loop of the 2026 pet breakouts with the stopping points and co-op ritual of 99 Nights and the showcase-and-trade life of the classics. The policies that hurt Steal An Egg-style endless feeds become a moat for a game designed around nights that end. Harry's edge is not novelty in mechanics, which will be copied within weeks. It is execution in the places most teams cut corners: a first minute that hooks, a shop that converts without deceiving, and odds and age rules handled correctly from the start.

The realistic outcome is modest, and Harry should plan for it. A disciplined ten-week MVP that reaches a few hundred CCU proves the skills clients pay for, because the shop, odds UI, saving and LiveOps tooling double as a public portfolio. It keeps a small chance of the outsized outcome open. The decisive evidence will come from Harry's own Creator Analytics in the first month after soft launch. D1, bounce and payer rate should decide whether he scales the game, pivots to one of the alternatives, or cuts losses. The key open checks before committing money are DevEx payout reach in Nigeria, the exact current wording of the paid-random-item and stopping-point rules, and whether the chosen name and art direction are clear of existing games.